

Temperate forest wildlife

The temperate forests of south and east Australia are hot and dry in summer, and cooler and wetter in winter. They are home to birds, such as parrots and kookaburras, marsupials, including the koala, and a variety of reptiles and insects. Many trees found here, such as eucalyptus and mountain ash, are unique to Australia.

Kookaburra

The kookaburra is the largest member of the kingfisher family. It is rarely found near water, however, preferring open woodland. Kookaburras swoop down from a tree branch perch to pounce on insects, lizards, snakes, and small birds and mammals. They defend their territory by making loud cackling calls that sound like human laughter.

Flattened tail helps platypus swim.



Duck-billed platypus

This unusual-looking animal is an egg-laying mammal, or monotreme, that lives near rivers. The platypus feeds underwater on insect larvae and other food found by probing the stream bottom with its sensitive bill. It hunts mainly at night, spending most of the day in a burrow dug in the stream bank.

Male lyrebird sings a loud territorial song, mimicking other birds and animals.



Lyrebird

These ground-living birds use their large clawed feet to turn over stones and break open logs, in search of insects. The male lyrebird has a long tail shaped like a lyre, an ancient musical instrument. He performs courtship dances to attract females by vibrating his tail over his back.

Long tail feathers

Koalas spend most of their time in eucalyptus trees, using their sharp claws and strong legs to climb through the branches.



Bright yellow flowers provide food for insects and other animals.



Koala

Koalas are bear-like marsupials that feed on the leaves of eucalyptus trees. They eat mainly at night, spending most of the day resting or sleeping in the fork of a tree.



Tree kangaroo

The tree kangaroo is a marsupial adapted for life in the trees, by having rough paw pads and long claws for gripping. Its diet consists mainly of leaves and bark, but it sometimes descends to the ground to feed on shrubs and seedlings.

Long tail for balancing in the trees.

Rainbow lorikeet

These brightly coloured parrots live in screeching flocks of up to 20 birds in the upper rainforest canopy. They feed on pollen, nectar, flowers, seeds, and fruit.

The male is brightly coloured.



Queen Alexandra's birdwing

Found in New Guinea, this is the largest butterfly in the world. The female is larger than the male and has a wingspan of up to 28 cm (11 in). Queen Alexandra's birdwing flies in the sunlight of the upper canopy, where it feeds on flower nectar.



Tropical rainforest wildlife

Despite occupying only a tiny part of northeastern Australia, the rainforests contain one-third of Australia's frog and marsupial species, and two-thirds of its butterflies. The wide variety of ferns and trees, such as breadfruit trees, provide shelter and food for these animals, and many birds, bats, and insects.

Trigger plant

When a bee lands on a trigger plant flower, the anther – the flower's male part – bends outwards to dust pollen on the bee's hairy back. When the bee visits another flower the pollen sticks to the stigma – the female part of the flower, thereby pollinating it.

Pink flowers attract bees.



Fangs are 1 cm (0.5 in) long so they can inject venom deep into their victims.

Taipan

This forest snake is active in the early morning and evening, and feeds mainly on rats and other small mammals. The taipan is one of the world's most poisonous snakes; a bite from its long fangs is often fatal for humans. Taipans normally retreat and hide when people approach, but they will become aggressive if threatened.



Brown coloration provides camouflage for taipan.

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